

4. OpenClaw TUI Interaction

4. OpenClaw TUI Interaction

1. How to Enter TUI
2. What is the TUI Interface
3. Slash Commands
4. Session and Memory
 - 4.1 Where are Session Files
 - 4.2 How to "Use" Memory
5. Quick Start Flow
6. Common Troubleshooting
 - 6.1 Entered a command but no response
 - 6.2 Feel "it's started talking nonsense, can't understand people" or being disturbed by history
 - 6.3 Responses getting slower

TUI (Text User Interface) is OpenClaw's "command-line chat window". When it's inconvenient to open the web console on the RDK, or when you're connected via SSH remotely, the TUI allows you to complete most daily interactions directly in the terminal: conversation, model switching, status viewing, session management, skill invocation, etc.

```
openclaw tui - ws://127.0.0.1:18789 - agent main - session tui-d22f3413-3bc0-4731-80f0-e356e3ca3146
session agent:main:tui-d22f3413-3bc0-4731-80f0-e356e3ca3146
new session: tui-d22f3413-3bc0-4731-80f0-e356e3ca3146

Slash commands:
/help
/commands
/status
/agent <id> (or /agents)
/session <key> (or /sessions)
/model <provider/models> (or /models)
/think <off|minimal|low|medium|high|adaptive>
/verbose <on|off>
/reasoning <on|off>
/usage <off|tokens|full>
/elevated <on|off|ask|full>
/relev <on|off|ask|full>
/activation <mention|always>
/new or /reset
/abort
/settings
/exit
connected | idle
agent main | session tui-d22f3413-3bc0-4731-80f0-e356e3ca3146 (openclaw-tui) | baillan/qwen3.5-plus | tokens 7/1.0m
```

1. How to Enter TUI

Execute in the terminal:

```
openclaw tui
```

If you have already started the OpenClaw gateway in another terminal (e.g., as a gateway/server), you can directly execute `openclaw tui` to enter the interaction interface.

For non-Docker versions, openclaw gateway does not need to be started manually and will start automatically on boot.

For Docker versions, you need to open a terminal first and manually run openclaw gateway to start the gateway.

2. What is the TUI Interface

You can think of TUI as a "chat box with commands":

- Top: Conversation history (your messages, model replies, tool/skill outputs)
- Bottom: Input box (enter questions or send slash commands)
- Send method: Press Enter after input to send

It is recommended to do two things when entering for the first time:

```
/status
```

3. Slash Commands

Slash commands generally need to be sent as independent messages starting with `/`. They are used to control sessions and perform operations.

Command	Function	When to Use	Example
<code>/help</code>	View help and command list	Don't know what commands are available	<code>/help</code>
<code>/status</code>	View current status	Suspect not connected, want to see context usage	<code>/status</code>
<code>/new</code>	Start a new conversation line (new session)	Topic change, avoid context interference	<code>/new</code>
<code>/reset</code>	Reset session (equivalent to starting over, same as new)	Conversation went off track, want to clear context	<code>/reset</code>
<code>/model /models list</code>	View/switch models	Want to switch to a faster or more powerful model	<code>/models list</code>
<code>/think medium</code>	Set thinking depth	Daily recommendation: low or off	<code>/think medium</code>
<code>/stop</code>	Abort current task	Stuck, want to stop immediately	<code>/stop</code>
<code>/context detail</code>	View currently injected context	Troubleshoot "why it remembers/forgets certain things"	<code>/context detail</code>
<code>/compact</code>	Compact earlier history into summary	Conversation too long, context almost full	<code>/compact</code>
<code>/skill <name></code>	Run a specific skill	You know the skill name and want to run it directly	<code>/skill web_search</code>

Additional "daily feel" suggestions:

- When sending a message with a slash command, it's safest to write only one slash command per message
- To quickly browse all commands, use `/help` or `/commands`

4. Session and Memory

In OpenClaw, these two concepts have clear divisions:

- Session: Manages "where this conversation has gotten to". When you use `/new`, `/reset` in TUI, you are essentially switching/reopening sessions.
- Memory: Manages "content that should be retained long-term across sessions". It is written to disk (Markdown) and retrieved back to the current session when needed.

4.1 Where are Session Files

Sessions are saved to disk in JSONL format. Common locations (based on actual installation path):

- Index: `~/.openclaw/agents/<agentId>/sessions/sessions.json`
- Transcription: `~/.openclaw/agents/<agentId>/sessions/<SessionId>.jsonl`

A more convenient way for actual troubleshooting is to execute first:

```
openclaw status
```

It usually gives the store path and recent session information.

4.2 How to "Use" Memory

You can think of Memory as "having the robot take notes":

- `memory/YYYY-MM-DD.md`: Daily process records, suitable for recording progress, temporary decisions
- `MEMORY.md`: Long-term stable information (preferences, fixed rules, project constraints, etc.)

Practical suggestions:

- Want a conclusion to be usable across sessions: Just tell the robot "write this to MEMORY.md"
- Preparing to use `/new` to switch topics: First use `/compact` or write key decisions to Memory, then switch sessions

5. Quick Start Flow

1. Enter TUI: `openclaw tui`
2. Confirm status: `/status`
3. Select model: `/models list` → `/model <number or name>`
4. Daily conversation: Just enter questions and press Enter
5. Topic switch: `/new`
6. Context too long: `/compact`
7. Key conclusions to retain long-term: Have the robot write to Memory

6. Common Troubleshooting

6.1 Entered a command but no response

- Confirm the command is sent on its own line (don't mix with plain text)
- Use `/help` first to see which commands are supported in the current version

6.2 Feel "it's started talking nonsense, can't understand people" or being disturbed by history

- Start a new session: `/new` or `/reset`
- Check what context has been injected: `/context detail`

6.3 Responses getting slower

- Lower thinking depth: `/think low` or `/think minimal`
- Compact history: `/compact`